I suspected he was referring to my recent loss of virginity. Inglorious episode, with an older woman. She liked horses, quite a lot, and treated me not unlike a young stallion. Quick ride, after which she'd smacked my rump and sent me off to graze. Among the many things about it that were wrong: It happened in a grassy field behind a busy pub.

Obviously someone had seen us.

The truth, Marko?

About whether or not you're doing drugs, Harry.

What?

It seemed that the editor of Britain's biggest tabloid had recently phoned my father's office to say she'd uncovered "evidence" of my doing drugs in various locations, including Club H. Also, a bike shed behind a pub. (Not the pub where I'd lost my virginity.) My father's office immediately dispatched Marko to take a clandestine meeting with one of this editor's lieutenants, in some shady hotel room, and the lieutenant laid out the tabloid's case. Now Marko laid it out for me.

He asked again if it was true.

Lies, I said. All lies.

He went item by item through the editor's evidence. I disputed all of it. Wrong, wrong, wrong. The basic facts, the details, it was all wrong.

I then questioned Marko. Who the hell is this editor?

Loathsome toad, I gathered. Everyone who knew her was in full agreement that she was an infected pustule on the arse of humanity, plus a shit excuse for a journalist. But none of that mattered, because she'd managed to wriggle her way into a position of great power and lately she was focusing all that power upon… me. She was hunting the Spare, straight out, and making no apologies for it. She wouldn't stop until my balls were nailed to her office wall.

I was lost. *For doing basic teenage stuff, Marko?*

No, boy, no.

In this editor's estimation, Marko said, I was a drug addict.

A *what?*

And one way or another, Marko said, that was the story she was going to publish.

I offered a suggestion about what this editor could do with her story. I told Marko to go back, tell her she had it all wrong.

He promised he would.